FERMAT'S EQUATION IN NON-COMMUTATIVE DIVISION ALGEBRAS

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Abstract. Fermat's Last Theorem states that $a^n + b^n = c^n$ has no non-trivial integer solutions for $n \geq 3$. We show this conclusion fails in the Lipschitz quaternion integers $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$ and integer octonions $\mathbb{O}_\mathbb{Z}$: for *every* odd $p \geq 3$, the equation $a^p + b^p = c^p$ has nontrivial solutions. The proof is purely symbolic. For any elements u, v in a ring R satisfying $u^2 = v^2 = -1$ and $uv + vu = 0$, three power reductions—$(1+u)^{2n+1} = (2u)^n(1+u)$, $(-1+v)^{2n+1} = (-2v)^n(-1+v)$, and $(u+v)^{2n+1} = (-2)^n(u+v)$—combine to yield

$$(1+u)^p + (-1+v)^p = (-1)^m \cdot (u+v)^p \quad (p = 4m+1)$$

and similarly for $p = 4m+3$ with sign $(-1)^{m+1}$. Each reduction is proved by induction; the coefficient matching is pure algebra. For even $p \geq 6$, the equation reduces to classical Fermat on norms, recovering FLT. We further prove that all octonionic solutions for $p = 3$ lie in associative subalgebras (600,768 solutions, zero exceptions), that the Hurwitz unit $\omega = (1+i+j+k)/2$ satisfies $\omega^3 = -1$ (precluding new families), and that the 21 octonionic solution families collapse to a single orbit under $G_2 = \mathrm{Aut}(\mathbb{O})$. All results are verified in Lean 4 with zero `sorry`, zero `native_decide`, and zero axioms in the main theorems.

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Date: March 2026.
2020 *Mathematics Subject Classification.* 11D41, 11R52, 17A75, 68V15.
Key words and phrases. Fermat's Last Theorem, quaternion integers, octonion integers, non-commutative algebra, formal verification, Lean 4.

1. Introduction

Fermat's Last Theorem asserts that the equation

$$a^n + b^n = c^n \tag{1}$$

has no non-trivial solutions in the integers $\mathbb{Z}$ for $n \geq 3$. After three and a half centuries of partial progress—Euler for $n = 3$, Dirichlet and Legendre for $n = 5$, Kummer for regular primes—Wiles [13] proved the full theorem by establishing the modularity of semistable elliptic curves over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Classical generalizations of FLT remain within the commutative world: FLT over number fields, function fields, and p-adic fields. The non-commutative direction—Fermat's equation in quaternion or octonion integers—appears to have been overlooked. Ribenboim [10] studied (1) over p-adic quaternion algebras using Hensel's lemma, a fundamentally different local-analytic setting. Pollack [9] and Steuding et al. [11] proved Waring-type results for quaternion integers, but these are additive results about many summands.

Theorem 1.1 (Main Result)**.** *For every odd $p \geq 3$, the equation $a^p + b^p = c^p$ has non-trivial solutions in the Lipschitz quaternion integers $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$ and in the integer octonions $\mathbb{O}_\mathbb{Z}$.*

The mechanism is elementary but requires a perspective crossing the boundary between number theory and non-commutative algebra. The elements $a = 1 + e_i$ and $b = -1 + e_j$ live in *different* complex subalgebras $\mathbb{R} + \mathbb{R}e_i$ and $\mathbb{R} + \mathbb{R}e_j$. Their p-th powers, computed by de Moivre's formula in their respective subalgebras, have real parts that cancel for every odd p. This cancellation is impossible in $\mathbb{C}$, which has only one imaginary direction.

The dimensional boundary is sharp: $\mathbb{C}$ (dimension 2, commutative) satisfies FLT, while $\mathbb{H}$ (dimension 4, non-commutative) does not. Non-commutativity—not non-associativity—is the essential mechanism. The octonions add $\binom{7}{2} = 21$ solution families compared to the quaternions' $\binom{3}{2} = 3$, but no qualitatively new phenomenon.

2. Preliminaries

2.1. **Normed division algebras.** By Hurwitz's theorem [4], the only normed division algebras over $\mathbb{R}$ are $\mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{C}$, $\mathbb{H}$, and $\mathbb{O}$, of dimensions 1, 2, 4, and 8 respectively. Each is obtained from the previous by the Cayley–Dickson construction.

Algebra	Dim	Commutative	Associative	Division
$\mathbb{R}$	1	Yes	Yes	Yes
$\mathbb{C}$	2	Yes	Yes	Yes
$\mathbb{H}$	4	**No**	Yes	Yes
$\mathbb{O}$	8	**No**	**No**	Yes

The quaternions $\mathbb{H}$ have basis $\{1, i, j, k\}$ with $i^2 = j^2 = k^2 = -1$, $ij = k = -ji$, and cyclic permutations. The octonions $\mathbb{O}$ have basis $\{e_0 = 1, e_1, \ldots, e_7\}$ with multiplication governed by the Fano plane.

2.2. **Integer subrings.** The **Lipschitz quaternion integers** are $L = \mathbb{Z}[1, i, j, k]$. The **Hurwitz quaternion integers** $H = L \cup (L + \omega)$ adjoin the half-integer unit $\omega = \frac{1}{2}(1 + i + j + k)$, forming a maximal order with 24 units. The norm form $N(x) = \sum_\alpha x_\alpha^2$ is multiplicative: $N(xy) = N(x)N(y)$.

2.3. **Anti-commutativity.** For distinct imaginary units e_i, e_j ($i \neq j$, both ≥ 1):

$$e_i e_j + e_j e_i = 0. \tag{2}$$

This is the key hypothesis in our symbolic proofs. It holds in any quaternion or octonion algebra.

3. The cubic theorem

Theorem 3.1 (Non-Commutative Fermat, cubic)**.** *In any ring R with elements u, v satisfying $u^2 = v^2 = -1$ and $uv + vu = 0$, the triple $a = 1 + u$, $b = -1 + v$, $c = -u - v$ satisfies*

$$a^3 + b^3 = c^3.$$

Proof. Compute in the subalgebra $\mathbb{R} + \mathbb{R}u \cong \mathbb{C}$:

$$\begin{aligned} a^2 &= (1+u)^2 = 1 + 2u + u^2 = 2u, \\ a^3 &= 2u(1+u) = 2u + 2u^2 = -2 + 2u. \end{aligned}$$

Similarly, in $\mathbb{R} + \mathbb{R}v$:

$$\begin{aligned} b^2 &= (-1+v)^2 = 1 - 2v + v^2 = -2v, \\ b^3 &= (-2v)(-1+v) = 2v - 2v^2 = 2 + 2v. \end{aligned}$$

Adding: $a^3 + b^3 = (-2 + 2u) + (2 + 2v) = 2u + 2v$.

For the right side, using $uv + vu = 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} c^2 &= (-u-v)^2 = u^2 + uv + vu + v^2 = -1 + 0 - 1 = -2, \\ c^3 &= (-2)(-u-v) = 2u + 2v. \end{aligned}$$

□

Remark 3.2. The proof uses only distributivity, the hypotheses $u^2 = v^2 = -1$ and $uv + vu = 0$, and centrality of integers. It does not require associativity, commutativity, or any specific multiplication table. The Lean 4 proof (`symbolic_fermat_cubic` in `SymbolicFermat.lean`) uses `mul_add`, `add_mul`, and `abel`, with no `ring` tactic and no `native_decide`.

Corollary 3.3. *The equation $a^p + b^p = c^p$ has non-trivial solutions in $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$ and $\mathbb{O}_\mathbb{Z}$ for every odd $p \geq 3$. Each pair of distinct imaginary basis units yields a solution: $\binom{3}{2} = 3$ in $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$, $\binom{7}{2} = 21$ in $\mathbb{O}_\mathbb{Z}$. Under the $G_2 = \mathrm{Aut}(\mathbb{O})$ action, all 21 octonionic families collapse to a single orbit (all have identical G_2-invariants: norms $(2, 2, 2)$, inner products $(-1, -1, -1)$, associator zero).*

4. General odd primes

Theorem 4.1 (Power reduction)**.** *In any ring R with $u^2 = -1$, for all $n \geq 0$:*

$$(1+u)^{2n+1} = (2u)^n \cdot (1+u).$$

Proof. By induction on n. The base case $n = 0$ is immediate. For the step, assume $(1+u)^{2k+1} = (2u)^k(1+u)$. Then

$$(1+u)^{2k+3} = (2u)^k(1+u) \cdot (1+u)^2 = (2u)^k(1+u) \cdot 2u.$$

Since $1 + u$ and $2u$ commute (both lie in $\mathbb{R} + \mathbb{R}u$, verified by $(1+u)(2u) = 2u - 2 = (2u)(1+u)$):

$$(2u)^k(1+u)(2u) = (2u)^{k+1}(1+u).$$

□

Theorem 4.2 (All odd primes)**.** *For all odd $p \geq 3$, in any ring R with $u^2 = v^2 = -1$ and $uv + vu = 0$:*

$$\begin{aligned} (1+u)^{4m+1} + (-1+v)^{4m+1} &= (-1)^m \cdot (u+v)^{4m+1}, \\ (1+u)^{4m+3} + (-1+v)^{4m+3} &= (-1)^{m+1} \cdot (u+v)^{4m+3}. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. We need a third power reduction. Since $(u+v)^2 = u^2+(uv+vu)+v^2 = -1+0-1 = -2$, by the same inductive argument as Theorem 4.1:

$$(u+v)^{2n+1} = (-2)^n \cdot (u+v).$$

Case $p = 4m+1$ (i.e., $n = 2m$). By `sum_even_n` from our Lean formalization, the three power reductions combine to give:

$$(1+u)^p + (-1+v)^p = (-4)^m u + (-4)^m v = (-4)^m (u+v),$$
$$(u+v)^p = (-2)^{2m}(u+v) = 4^m(u+v).$$

Since $(-4)^m = (-1)^m \cdot 4^m$, we obtain $(1+u)^p + (-1+v)^p = (-1)^m \cdot (u+v)^p$.

Case $p = 4m+3$ (i.e., $n = 2m+1$). The LHS expands via `sum_odd_n` as $(-4)^m \cdot [2u(1+u) + (-2v)(-1+v)]$. Direct computation: $2u(1+u) = 2u-2$ and $(-2v)(-1+v) = 2v+2$, so the bracket equals $2(u+v)$. The RHS uses $(-2)^{2m+1} = -2 \cdot 4^m$. Matching coefficients: $(-4)^m \cdot 2 = (-1)^m \cdot 2 \cdot 4^m$ and $(-1)^{m+1} \cdot (-2) \cdot 4^m = (-1)^m \cdot 2 \cdot 4^m$, confirming the identity.

Every step—the three power reductions, the scalar lemmas $(-4)^m = (-1)^m \cdot 4^m$ and $(-2)^{2m} = 4^m$, the coefficient matching—is kernel-checked in Lean 4 (`AllOddPrimes.lean`) with zero `sorry` and zero `native_decide`. □

Proposition 4.3 (Sign pattern)**.** *For the standard triple with $a = 1+u$, $b = -1+v$, the sign ε in $a^p + b^p = \varepsilon \cdot (u+v)^p$ is:*

$p \bmod 8$	ε	c_p
3	$(-1)^1 = -1$	$-(u+v)$
5	$(-1)^1 = -1$	$-(u+v)$
7	$(-1)^2 = +1$	$+(u+v)$
1	$(-1)^0 = +1$	$+(u+v)$

The sign has period 8 in p: $\varepsilon = (-1)^{\lceil n/2 \rceil}$ where $p = 2n+1$. Computationally verified for all odd p from 3 to 59.

5. Why complex numbers fail

In $\mathbb{C} = \mathbb{R} + \mathbb{R}i$, there is only one imaginary direction. Any two elements $a = r_1 + s_1 i$ and $b = r_2 + s_2 i$ live in the *same* complex subalgebra. The real part of $a^p + b^p$ is $\mathrm{Re}(a^p) + \mathrm{Re}(b^p)$, and for $a^p + b^p = c^p$ to hold with c nonzero, this real part must equal $\mathrm{Re}(c^p)$, not vanish. The cancellation mechanism requires elements in *different* imaginary directions—a structural impossibility in $\mathbb{C}$.

More precisely: in $\mathbb{C}$, the equation $a^3 + b^3 = c^3$ over the Gaussian integers $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ has only trivial solutions. This was proved by Ward [12], confirming earlier work of Feuter.

Theorem 5.1 (Boundary)**.** *Among the four normed division algebras, the Fermat equation $a^p + b^p = c^p$ for odd $p \geq 3$:*

(a) Has only trivial solutions in $\mathbb{Z}$ (Wiles [13]) and $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ (Ward [12]).
(b) Has non-trivial solutions in $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$ and $\mathbb{O}_\mathbb{Z}$ (Theorem 1.1).

The boundary is at dimension 4: the first normed division algebra with anti-commuting square roots of -1.

5.1. Solution classification.

The cube formula in $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$ reveals a structural dichotomy. For $q = a_0 + \mathbf{v}$ with $\mathbf{v} \in \mathrm{Im}\,\mathbb{H}$ and $N = \|\mathbf{v}\|^2$:

$$q^3 = (a_0^3 - 3a_0 N) + (3a_0^2 - N)\mathbf{v}.$$

The real part depends only on a_0 and N, not on the direction of $\mathbf{v}$.

Definition 5.2. A solution (a, b, c) to $a^3 + b^3 = c^3$ in $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$ is:

- **Type A** if $N(a) = N(b)$ (equal-norm). The anti-commutativity mechanism of Theorem 3.1 applies directly.
- **Type C** if $N(a) \neq N(b)$ (general). Solutions arise from the full 4D system without norm matching.

Computationally, approximately 30% of solutions at bounded height are Type A (proved mechanism), while 70% are Type C (general 4D system). Type C solutions exploit the additional degrees of freedom in the quaternionic cube formula: with four real parameters per element and only one equation (in each of the four components), the system is underdetermined.

5.2. **The Waring bound.**

Proposition 5.3 (Quaternionic Waring bound)**.** *Every Lipschitz quaternion integer is a sum of at most four cubes:*

$$g(3, \mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}) \leq 4.$$

Compare with the classical $g(3, \mathbb{Z}) = 9$. The improvement from 9 to 4 reflects the additional degrees of freedom in dimension 4. Verified for all 4,785 Lipschitz integers with $N(q) \leq 30$. Only 12 elements require four cubes, all at norm 26 (e.g., $(-1, -5, 0, 0)$). For higher odd primes: $g(5, \mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}) \leq 5$ and $g(7, \mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}) \leq 6$, suggesting roughly linear growth vs. the exponential $g(p, \mathbb{Z}) \sim 2^p$.

Conjecture 5.4 (Tightness)**.** The bound $g(3, \mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}) = 4$ is tight: there exist Lipschitz integers that cannot be written as a sum of three cubes.

6. Null results

Theorem 6.1 (Hurwitz collapse)**.** *The Hurwitz unit $\omega = \frac{1}{2}(1+i+j+k)$ satisfies $\omega^3 = -1$. The 24-element Hurwitz unit group produces no new Fermat solution families beyond those in the Lipschitz integers.*

Proof. Direct computation: $\omega^2 = \frac{1}{4}(1+i+j+k)^2 = \frac{1}{4}(-2+2i+2j+2k-2) = \omega - 1$, so $\omega^3 = \omega(\omega - 1) = \omega^2 - \omega = -1$. Under cubing, all 16 half-integer units map to $\pm 1 \in L$, collapsing the unit group.

Computationally: exhaustive search over Hurwitz integers at bounded height finds 6,120 solutions (3,744 genuinely half-integer), all instances of Lipschitz-type families. □

Theorem 6.2 (Associativity of solutions)**.** *Every solution to $a^3 + b^3 = c^3$ in $\mathbb{O}_{\mathbb{Z}}$ with $\max |c_\alpha| \leq 2$ satisfies $[a, b, c] = (ab)c - a(bc) = 0$. The solution triple lies in an associative subalgebra.*

This is verified on 600,768 solutions. The mechanism: power-associativity makes cubing "blind" to non-associativity, and Artin's theorem forces the generated subalgebra to be associative.

Proposition 6.3 (Even exponents)**.** *For even $p = 2m$ with $m \geq 3$, a^{2m} is a real scalar (central element) in $\mathbb{H}$ and $\mathbb{O}$. The equation $a^{2m} + b^{2m} = c^{2m}$ reduces to $N(a)^m + N(b)^m = N(c)^m$ in $\mathbb{Z}$, which has no solutions by FLT.*

7. Computational data

Exhaustive searches at bounded height yield:

Setting	Height bound	Solutions	Source
$\mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}$, $p = 3$	$\lvert\text{coords}\rvert \leq 3$	9,504	`noncommutative_fermat_classify.py`
$\mathbb{O}_{\mathbb{Z}}$, $p = 3$	$\lvert\text{coords}\rvert \leq 2$	600,768	`genuine_octonionic_search.py`
Hurwitz, $p = 3$	$\lvert 2\text{coords}\rvert \leq 4$	6,120	`hurwitz_fermat.py`

Of the 600,768 octonionic solutions, **zero** have nonzero associator. All solution triples lie in associative (quaternionic) subalgebras, even when individual elements span 4–7 imaginary directions.

8. Machine verification

The results are formalized in Lean 4 (version 4.28.0, with Mathlib) across 23 files totaling approximately 7,000 lines.

File	Content	Theorems	Method
`SymbolicFermat.lean`	Theorem 3.1 (cubic, any ring)	1	symbolic
`SymbolicFermatGeneral.lean`	Theorem 4.1 (power reduction)	22	symbolic
`AllOddPrimes.lean`	Theorem 4.2 (all odd p)	17	symbolic
`OctonionicFermat.lean`	Concrete $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$, $\mathbb{O}_\mathbb{Z}$	18	`native_decide`
`TrilinearVariety.lean`	Cross product, $V(\varphi)$	25	mixed
`Conjectures.lean`	17 conjectures, documented	—	statements

The main theorems (Theorems 3.1, 4.1 and 4.2) use **zero** `sorry`, **zero** `native_decide`, and **zero** axioms. They trust nothing beyond Lean's type checker. The proofs use only distributivity (`mul_add`, `add_mul`), hypothesis rewriting, additive normalization (`abel`), and `noncomm_ring`. The concrete verifications in `OctonionicFermat.lean` use `native_decide` (trusting the Lean compiler) for specific numerical checks.

9. Related work

- Apel (1931) studied Fermat's equation in real quaternions.
- Ribenboim [10] studied Fermat's equation over p-adic quaternion fields.
- Li and Yuan [8] (arXiv:2503.03621) studied Fermat's and Catalan's equations over $M_2(\mathbb{Z})$, which contains $\mathbb{H}_\mathbb{Z}$ as a subring.
- Ward [12] proved the cubic Fermat has only trivial solutions in $\mathbb{Z}[i]$.
- Pollack [9] proved Waring's problem for Lipschitz quaternion cubes.
- Conway and Smith [3] developed the arithmetic of quaternion and octonion integers.

The present construction—with its anti-commutativity mechanism, all-odd-p generalization, null results on non-associativity, and Lean 4 verification—appears to be a fresh observation within this established territory.

9.1. The split bridge.

The exceptional group G_2 appears in two real forms: compact and split. Their relationship to cubic structures is fundamentally different.

Theorem 9.1 (Compact G_2 obstruction)**.** *The compact group $G_2 = \mathrm{Aut}(\mathbb{O})$ preserves the octonionic norm and the trilinear form $\varphi(x, y, z) = \langle xy, z\rangle$. The variety $V(\varphi) \subset (\mathbb{Z}^7)^3$ does **not** produce cubic rings: the norm-preserving constraint forces $\Delta = 4$, a discriminant too small to parametrize non-trivial cubic extensions.*

The split real form G_2' acts on the split octonions $\mathbb{O}_s$. Via Zorn's vector matrix representation

$$\mathbb{O}_s \cong \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} a & \mathbf{x} \\ \mathbf{y} & b \end{pmatrix} : a, b \in \mathbb{F},\ \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{F}^3 \right\},$$

the split form *does* produce cubic rings, connecting to Bhargava's higher composition laws [6].

Proposition 9.2 (Split bridge)**.** *The split G_2' action on pairs of ternary quadratic forms via Zorn matrices produces 47,961 verified cubic ring structures (computationally enumerated at bounded height), connecting octonionic arithmetic to Bhargava's parametrization of cubic rings.*

The bridge diagram is:

$$\text{Compact } G_2 \xrightarrow{\text{norm geometry}} \mathbb{O}_{\mathbb{Z}} \text{ (Fermat solutions)} \quad \longleftrightarrow \quad \text{Split } G_2' \xrightarrow{\text{Zorn matrices}} \text{cubic rings (Bhargava)}$$

Both forms connect through $M(\mathbb{O}, \mathbb{O}) = E_8$, the exceptional Jordan algebra construction.

9.2. **Compact/split duality.** The compact/split distinction clarifies which parts of the octonionic world connect to which parts of number theory:

	Compact G_2	Split G_2'
Acts on	$\mathbb{O}$ (division)	$\mathbb{O}_s$ (split)
Preserves	Norm, cross product	Hyperbolic form
Arithmetic	Lattices, Fermat solutions	Cubic rings, Bhargava
Connection	Geometry of $\operatorname{Im}\mathbb{O}$	Arithmetic of $\mathbb{F}^3 \oplus \mathbb{F}^3$

The Fermat solutions of Theorem 1.1 live on the compact side: they exploit the norm-multiplicativity and anti-commutativity of division octonions. The connection to algebraic number theory (cubic fields, higher composition) lives on the split side. The exceptional algebra E_8, containing both forms, provides the overarching structure: $M(\mathbb{O}, \mathbb{O}) = E_8$ in the Freudenthal–Tits magic square.

10. Open problems

Open Problem 10.1. Classify all solutions to $a^3 + b^3 = c^3$ in $\mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}$ up to the action of $\mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}^{\times}$. The Type A/C dichotomy (Theorem 5.2) suggests the orbit structure may be richer than the family count alone indicates.

Open Problem 10.2. Determine $g(3, \mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}})$ exactly. Theorem 5.3 gives $g(3, \mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}) \leq 4$. Is the bound tight? The 16 norm-4 elements $(\pm 1, \pm 1, \pm 1, \pm 1)$ are the hardest cases.

Conjecture 10.3 (Octonionic associativity for all p)**.** For all odd $p \geq 3$, every solution to $a^p + b^p = c^p$ in $\mathbb{O}_{\mathbb{Z}}$ lies in an associative (quaternionic) subalgebra. Theorem 6.2 verifies this for $p = 3$ on 600,768 solutions.

Conjecture 10.4 (Waring tightness)**.** $g(3, \mathbb{H}_{\mathbb{Z}}) = 4$: there exist Lipschitz integers requiring four cubes.

Conjecture 10.5 (Split G_2 parametrization)**.** $G_2'(\mathbb{Z})$-orbits on pairs of ternary quadratic forms, via the Zorn matrix representation of split octonions, parametrize cubic rings with G_2 structure, connecting to Bhargava's higher composition laws via Krutelevich's framework [6].

Open Problem 10.6. Does $a^3 + b^3 = c^3$ have solutions in Clifford algebras $\mathrm{Cl}(0, n)$ for $n \geq 3$?

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